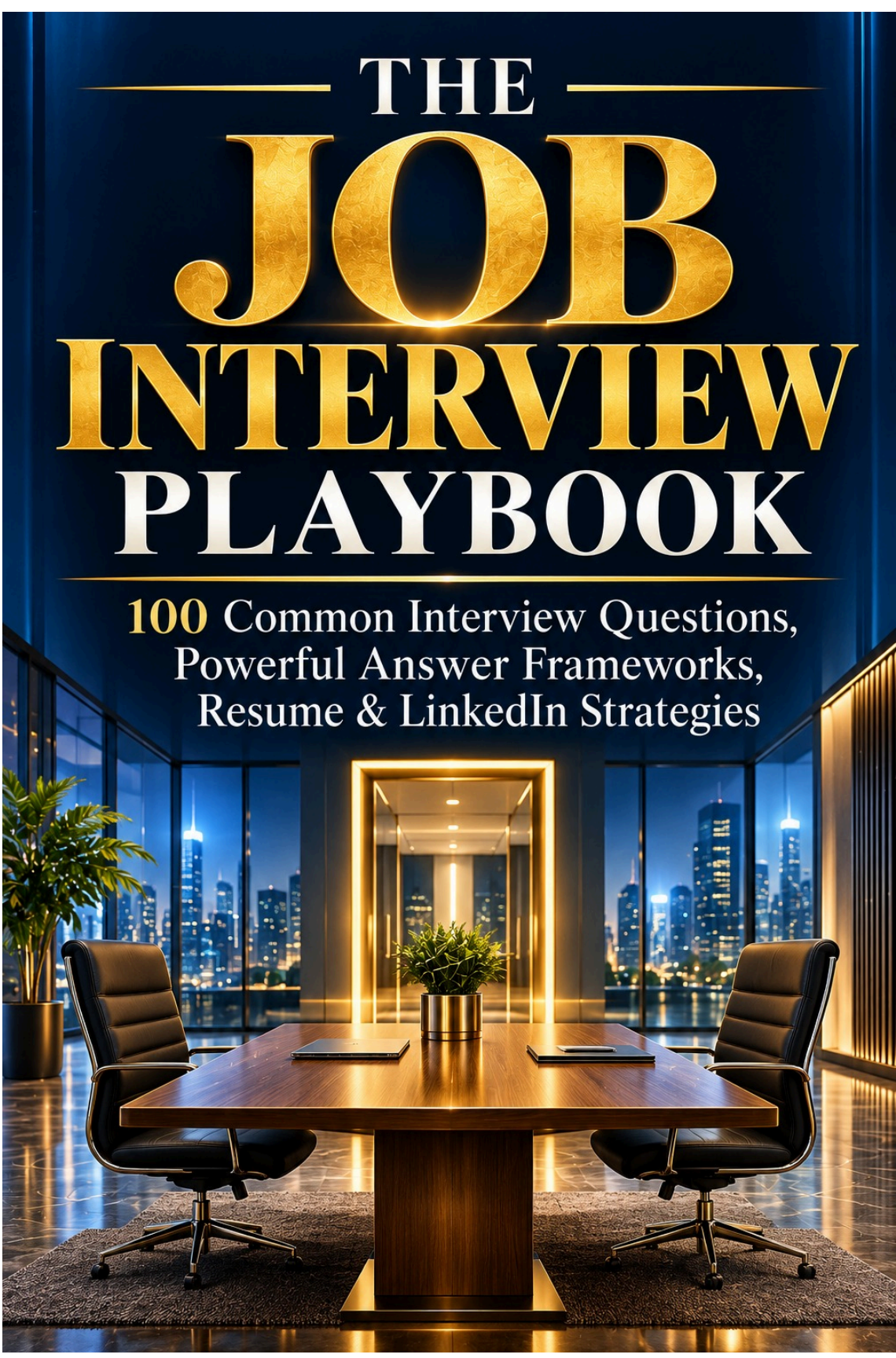
THE JOB INTERVIEW PLAYBOOK

100 Common Interview Questions, Powerful Answer Frameworks, Resume & LinkedIn Strategies



About this free sample

THE JOB INTERVIEW PLAYBOOK

100 Common Interview Questions, Powerful Answer Frameworks, Resume & LinkedIn Strategies

This sample shows the cover, the full contents, the plain-text resume structure, the STAR answer worksheet, six of the 100 interview questions in full (each with what the interviewer wants, an answer framework, an example answer, common mistakes and beginner and experienced adaptations), and salary negotiation scripts, exactly as they appear in the book.

The full book has 97 pages. Page numbers in the contents refer to the full book; sample pages keep their original page numbers.

This book is general career guidance. It does not guarantee interviews, offers or any outcome. Hiring practices differ by employer and country. Example answers are fictional illustrations: use your own true experience.

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Plain text ATS safe structure

```
FULL NAME
City, Country | phone | email | LinkedIn URL

SUMMARY (2 lines, optional for students)
SKILLS (grouped, comma separated)
EXPERIENCE
  Job title, Employer, City, Month Year - Month Year
  - bullet
  - bullet
EDUCATION
  Degree, Institution, Year
PROJECTS / CERTIFICATIONS (if relevant)
```

Example 1: beginner (fictional)

```
PRIYA NAIR
Pune, India | +91 00000 00000 | priya.nair@example.com

SUMMARY
Final-year commerce student with retail and tutoring experience,
seeking a junior accounts role.

SKILLS
Excel (pivot tables, lookups), Tally basics, written reports,
customer service

EXPERIENCE
Sales Assistant, Corner Books, Pune, Jun 2024 - Present
- Reconcile daily cash and card totals for a three-person shift
- Built a stock sheet in Excel that the owner now uses weekly
Peer Tutor, Commerce Department, Jan 2024 - Apr 2024
- Taught accounting basics to 8 first-year students weekly

EDUCATION
B.Com, Example University, expected 2026
```

Example 2: experienced (fictional)

```
DANIEL OKAFOR
Manchester, UK | 00000 000000 | daniel.okafor@example.com
```

Building a story bank

1. Use the 30 prompts in Appendix A. Write one or two lines per prompt. Many will be empty; that is normal.
2. Choose the six to eight richest. Include at least one failure, one conflict, one leadership moment, one improvement you made.
3. For each, write the true facts: dates, your role, numbers you actually know.
4. Tag each with the themes it can serve (teamwork, pressure, initiative).
5. Practise telling it in 90 seconds.

A single story can answer several questions. Reusing a good story is fine; reciting a memorised script is not. Know the facts, not the sentences.

STAR worksheet

```
Story title:
Situation (where, when, who):
Task (my responsibility):
Action (3 specific things I did, in order):
Result (what changed; number if known):
What I learned:
Themes it can answer:
```

Filled example (fictional)

```
Title: Late supplier at the bakery
Situation: Weekend rush, flour delivery missed, I was the
  duty supervisor.
Task: Keep the counter stocked for 200+ customers.
Action: Phoned two nearby shops for a loan, rebaked the best
  sellers first, told staff which items to prioritise.
Result: Sold out of only one line; owner changed supplier.
Learned: Keep a list of backup contacts.
Themes: pressure, initiative, problem-solving
```

Timing

Avoid discussing pay until you understand the role, ideally until the employer is ready to offer. If asked early, give a researched range and say you are flexible depending on the whole package. Negotiate after the written or verbal offer, not before. Thank them first.

Country differences

Practices differ: in some countries employers publish pay ranges, in others asking about previous salary is restricted or normal, and in some regions negotiating is expected while in others the offer is fixed by a grade scale. Rules differ by country and sometimes by region. Check your government's labour website or a local professional body before you rely on a rule.

Scripts

1. Responding to an early salary question

> I would like to learn more about the role first. Based on my research for similar roles in [city], I am looking at [range], and I am open to discussing the full package.

2. Asking for more after an offer

> Thank you, I am excited about the role. Based on [research and my experience in X], I was hoping for [figure]. Is there flexibility?

3. Offer is fixed

> I understand the salary band is fixed. Could we look at [start date / training budget / review at six months]?

4. Comparing with another offer (only if true)

```
I have another offer at [range], but your role is my first
choice. Is there anything you can do on salary?
```

5. Asking for time

```
Thank you for the offer. May I have until [date] to review
it and respond?
```

6. Accepting

```
I am pleased to accept at [salary] with the terms we
discussed. Please send the written offer.
```

7. Declining politely

```
Thank you for the offer and your time. I have decided to
decline because [brief reason]. I hope we can stay in touch.
```

If they say no, decide beforehand whether you will accept anyway. Never state a competing offer that does not exist.

CHAPTER 14

Introductory and personal questions (Q1 to Q20)

These questions open most interviews. Every example answer below is a fictional illustration: use it to see the shape, then build your own from true experience. Do not memorise or copy it.

Q1. Tell me about yourself.

What the interviewer wants to understand: Whether you can summarise your relevant background clearly and start the conversation well.

Answer framework: Past, present, future: one relevant past step, current focus, why this role. Under 90 seconds.

Example answer: "I studied environmental science and spent last summer at a river-monitoring charity, where I entered water-sample data and spotted a recording error in one site's readings. Now I am finishing my dissertation on urban run-off. I am applying here because I want to turn that analytical work into practical policy, and your team's local projects fit that."

Common mistakes: Reciting your life story, repeating the resume, or listing hobbies only.

Beginner adaptation: Lead with study, projects and one volunteer or part-time experience tied to the job.

Experienced candidate adaptation: Start with your current scope, one major result, and why the next step is this role.

Q2. Walk me through your resume.

What the interviewer wants to understand: Whether your career story is coherent and whether you can explain choices.

Answer framework: Chronological headlines, one sentence per role: what you did, what you learned, why you moved.

Example answer: "I started as a pharmacy assistant, learning stock control and customer care. I moved to a clinic receptionist role to work with patients directly, then into appointment coordination, where I redesigned the weekly schedule. Each move added responsibility. This role combines scheduling and patient contact, which are the parts I enjoy most."

Common mistakes: Reading dates aloud, spending too long on the oldest roles.

Beginner adaptation: Walk through education first, then projects and jobs, linking each to the role.

Experienced candidate adaptation: Compress early roles to one sentence; spend most time on the last two.

Q3. Why did you apply for this role?

What the interviewer wants to understand: Whether your interest is specific and genuine.

Answer framework: Two reasons from the posting, one skill you bring, one honest personal reason.

Example answer: "Your posting stresses forecasting for small retailers, which I did in my statistics project using a local shop's sales. I like work where numbers lead to a decision a real owner can act on. The role

CHAPTER 15

Behavioural questions (Q21 to Q40)

Each answer here should use a real STAR story from your own bank (Chapter 7).

Q21. Tell me about a time you failed.

What the interviewer wants to understand: Honesty, accountability and learning.

Answer framework: STAR plus Learning; own the cause; show what changed.

Example answer: "I missed a grant deadline because I assumed our partner would send the budget. I never confirmed. We submitted a day late and lost the round. I apologised to my director, wrote a checklist with a two-day confirmation step, and have used it on every application since. We have not missed a deadline in the three submissions after."

Common mistakes: Choosing a fake failure, or blaming others.

Beginner adaptation: A study, sport or part-time work failure is fine.

Experienced candidate adaptation: Pick a real professional miss with consequences and a lasting process change.

Q22. Tell me about a time you met a tight deadline.

What the interviewer wants to understand: Planning, prioritisation, and composure.

Answer framework: The constraint, your plan, your choices, the result.

Example answer: "Two days before a client launch, our translator fell ill. I listed what was essential, asked a bilingual colleague to check the key pages, and moved the remaining pages to a second release. The launch went ahead on time with the essential content, and the rest followed three days later."

Common mistakes: Saying you worked all night without explaining choices.

Beginner adaptation: Use an assignment or placement deadline.

Experienced candidate adaptation: Show triage and stakeholder communication.

Q23. Tell me about a time you handled criticism.

What the interviewer wants to understand: Openness to feedback.

Answer framework: What was said, your first reaction honestly, what you changed, result.

Example answer: "My tutor said my lab reports were accurate but hard to follow. I was annoyed at first, then asked for an example of a clear report. I changed my structure to put the result first. My next mark rose a grade, and I still use that layout."

Common mistakes: Claiming you never received criticism.

Beginner adaptation: Use tutor or coach feedback.